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UNDERSTANDING CHILDHOOD

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1.1 INTRODUCTION

This idea of childhood is often taken for granted, thinking that it is a natural and universal stage of life. But the idea of childhood is made up by society and history, and it changes across cultures, time and social settings. In the past, especially in agrarian societies, children were generally regarded as miniature adults who should help with chores around the house and family duties. Over time, formal schooling systems, legal changes, and worldwide human rights discussions have helped people see childhood as a separate and protected time for learning, playing, and growing. This changing perspective is the cornerstone for comprehending childhoods in modern India.

Childhood is different for everyone in the world today. In modern India, a child's upbringing is affected by a complicated combination of things like their family's socio-economic status, gender, culture, place of residence, and how

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much technology they have access to. Some children get good schools, safe places to live, and proper health care, while others deal with poverty, work, and being left out of society. This difference shows that there isn't just one childhood; there are many, each with its own set of problems and situations.

The idea of various childhoods takes this variety into account. In India, after birth, children's life is mostly influenced by their families and surroundings. For example, children from different economic backgrounds have different childhoods. Children from families with greater incomes frequently grow up in comfort, with access to private schools, digital tools, and after-school activities. On the other hand, children from middle-income homes may have limited access to these tools, but they also deal with stress from schoolwork, moving up in social status, and meeting their parents' expectations. Children, growing up in low-income households may not have easy access to school, and are forced to work at a young age. They also deal with financial problems, which make their childhood hard and short.

Gender also has profound impact on children's upbringing. Cultural conventions sometimes put differing expectations and limits on boys and girls. Some Girls may not be able to go to school or move around as much, while boys may be pushed to take on too much responsibility or act aggressively. These experiences that are different for boys and girls make growing up even harder.

Lastly, the emergence of digital world plays powerful role in how children grow up today. Many children, especially those who live in cities or wealthy areas, use digital devices for school, play, and socialization. But this also comes with concerns like screen addiction, cyberbullying, and unequal access, especially for children from under-represented groups. The digital divide makes existing disparities more and makes it harder to understand childhood in a society that is changing rapidly.

This chapter will explore the aforesaid ideas in detail so that a comprehensive perspective on childhood, their experiences, challenges and possibilities can be understood.

**1.2 LEARNING OUTCOMES**

After completion of this chapter, the learner

- conceptualises the concept of childhood;

- critically analyses the constituents of childhoods in contemporary times.
- comprehends that childhood experiences differ with regard to social, economic, cultural, and regional contexts in India;
- recognises gender as a factor that shapes childhood;
- reflects on the role of digitalization in shaping the experiences of childhood.

1.3 CONCEPTUALISATION OF THE IDEA OF CHILDHOOD

The idea of childhood is not fixed or universal; rather, it is a socially and historically constructed concept that has evolved over time. The conceptualisation of childhood reflects broader societal values, economic systems, and philosophical beliefs, and it varies significantly across cultures and historical periods.

Historically, in Western societies, childhood was not always viewed as a distinct phase of life. Philippe Ariès (1962), in his seminal work *Centuries of Childhood*, argued that in medieval Europe, children were seen as small adults, with little recognition of developmental differences. It was not until the 17th and 18th centuries, with the rise of Enlightenment thinking, that childhood began to be seen as a separate and important stage of human life, requiring specific care, protection, and education.

The philosophical contributions of John Locke and Jean-Jacques Rousseau significantly influenced modern views of childhood. Locke (1693) portrayed the child as a blank slate (*tabula rasa*), whose mind was shaped entirely by experience and education. Rousseau (1762), on the other hand, emphasised the innate goodness and natural development of children, advocating for child-centred education that aligns with a child's stage of growth. These early ideas laid the foundation for later psychological theories that conceptualised childhood as a period of cognitive, emotional, and moral development.

In the 20th century, developmental psychologists such as Jean Piaget and Erik Erikson further entrenched the notion of childhood as a biologically determined, universal process. Piaget (1952) introduced a stage-based model of cognitive development, suggesting that all children move through a fixed sequence of developmental phases. Erikson (1950) proposed psychosocial stages that highlighted the importance of social interaction in shaping identity throughout childhood. These perspectives became dominant in fields like education, psychology, and child welfare policy, reinforcing the idea that children are passive beings who require adult guidance to reach maturity (Burman, 2008).



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However, this dominant developmental model has been critiqued by sociologists and anthropologists for overlooking the diversity and agency of children's experiences. Scholars such as James and Prout (1997) argue that childhood is not merely a biological phase, but a social construct shaped by cultural, political, and economic contexts. This "new sociology of childhood" emphasises that children are active participants in their own social worlds and should be seen as social agents rather than passive dependents.

Moreover, cross-cultural studies have shown that what constitutes childhood varies widely. In many societies, children engage in work, contribute to household economies, and take on responsibilities at a young age. These practices challenge the Western ideal of a protected, education-centered childhood (Boyden, 1997). Therefore, contemporary understandings of childhood must account for pluralities—what has been termed the "multiple childhoods" perspective.

**CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 1.1**

1. What did Philippe Ariès say about how people thought about children in medieval Europe?
 - A. As people who need protection and education
 - B. As naturally decent beings who go through different stages of growth
 - C. As small adults with little recognition of developmental differences
 - D. As beings that need adult leadership and are inactive.
2. What did Jean-Jacques Rousseau contribute that helped people understand childhood better?
 - A. He said that childhood is predetermined biologically.
 - B. He believed that child is a blank slate.
 - C. He came up with the idea of psychological growth stages.
 - D. He emphasised on natural development and child-centred education.

Answers : 1-c; 2-d

Indian mythology has a lot of stories about childhood that are very meaningful and important to Indian culture. Hindu epics and Puranas show different notions about purity, divinity, discipline, and cosmic purpose through their characters Krishna, Rama, and Durga, who are all children.

Krishna's early existence in Vrindavan is full of playful innocence, charm, and amazing accomplishments, making him one of the most famous representations of boyhood. His joyful snatching of butter (makhan-chor) and defeating of demons show a heavenly presence coming into the world as a child, mixing joy and holiness (Pattanaik, 2005). His stories show that infancy isn't merely a time of growing; it may also be a time when the divine is fully present.

Rama, on the other hand, is shown as the perfect son in the Ramayana. He is obedient, calm, and responsible even as a child. Rama shows dharma (responsibility) from an early age, first with the help of the sage Vasistha and then with the help of Vishwamitra. His childhood stresses discipline and doing the right thing, which is a good example of how to raise a child morally (Goldman & Goldman, 2004). Female divinity can also be seen in childhood forms, especially in the goddess Durga as Kumari, who is adored as a child during rites like Kumari Puja in Bengal and Nepal. This tradition shows that girl children are pure and have hidden power. It goes against patriarchal ideas by linking femininity and childhood with strength and respect (Kinsley, 1988).

These mythological childhoods are more than just symbols; they have influenced cultural activities all over India, from naming ceremonies to children's stories and festivals. They show a view of childhood that goes beyond innocence and sees it as a time of divine potential, moral duty, and spiritual awareness.

Modern state policy and legal changes have as much of an impact on Indian childhood today as cultural traditions do. The Right to Education Act (RTE), which was passed in 2009, says that all children between the ages of 6 and 14 must go to school for free. It shows a change from traditional values to a view of childhood based on rights (Kumar, 2005).

Even though regulations are getting better, differences in wealth and social status still make it hard for some children to have an education, health care, and safety. Many low-income families still rely on their children to help with chores or make money, showing that the need for money often outweighs the idea of childhood as a time for learning and growth (Pratham, 2022).



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**CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 1.2**

1. What do the childhood stories of Krishna, Rama, and Durga represent?
2. Right to Education Act (RTE) of 2009 ensures:
 - A. Financial support for education
 - B. Education for all children upto 18
 - C. Compulsory and free education for children aged 6 to 14
 - D. Equal opportunities for Jobs

Answer: 2 - c

1.4 CHILDHOODS IN CONTEMPORARY TIMES

Compared to previous generations, childhood in the modern world has changed a lot. Changes in technology, family dynamics, the economy, and educational models have all changed how kids grow, learn, and interact with the world. These developments have brought a lot of good things, but they have also made things harder for children in terms of their physical, emotional, and social growth.

One of the most interesting things about modern childhood is how much technology affects it. Smartphones, tablets, and laptops are now an important part of everyday life, including school and play. People commonly call children “digital natives” because they grew up with technology all around them (Prensky, 2001). Digital tools can help people learn and be creative, but too much screen time has been related to problems like less physical activity, less sleep, and being alone (Twenge & Campbell, 2018). The widespread use of digital media has also raised worries about cyberbullying and the effects of social media on mental health, since it shows kids unrealistic body images, peer pressure, and harassment online. In modern India, digital technology and the media have also changed what it means to be a child. Children are exposed to commercial culture at a young age, which has affected their hopes, actions, and mental health (Singh, 2011). But there are still digital disparities, and students in rural and low-income areas don’t have equal access to technology-based schooling.

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Along with digital impacts, changing family dynamics also define children today. The rise in divorce, single parenthood, and homes with two incomes have transformed the way people traditionally care for others. A lot of children spend more time in daycare or with other caretakers, which can change how they feel and how they bond with people (Bowlby, 1988; Belsky, 2001). At the same time, broader definitions of family and a greater focus on emotional health have made it possible for certain children to grow up in more caring and supportive settings. This is a sign of a trend toward positive parenting.

There have also been big changes in education. There is more pressure on children to do well in school than ever before, and this pressure starts at a young age. Standardised tests and schools that are competitive might make people feel stressed and anxious (Pope, 2001). However, modern education has also adopted new methods including project-based learning, digital literacy, and inclusive education to meet the requirements of different learners and get children ready for a globalised world (UNESCO, 2021).

Today's children come from diverse social and economic backgrounds, each with unique experiences and opportunities. While some have access to quality education, nutritious food, and healthcare, global efforts are increasingly focused on ensuring that every child can enjoy these fundamental rights. According to UNICEF (2023), recognising that many children still face challenges such as poverty motivates collective action toward building a fairer world. Despite global issues like climate change, conflict, and the lingering effects of the COVID-19 pandemic (Loades et al., 2020), there is growing awareness, collaboration, and innovation aimed at creating more equitable opportunities and a brighter future for all children.

Modern Indian childhood reflects a dynamic blend of growth, opportunity, and transformation. On one hand, many middle-class families in cities are embracing progressive, child-centered approaches that value education, creativity, and emotional well-being. At the same time, growing awareness and ongoing efforts are bringing positive changes to rural and economically challenged areas, where initiatives in education, social protection, and community development are helping children realise their potential. With continued commitment to inclusive growth, legal reforms, and changing mindsets, India is steadily moving toward a future where every child—regardless of background—can thrive, learn, and contribute meaningfully to society.



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It can be said that childhood today is full of differences and complications. Technological and social progress have created numerous chances for people to grow and learn, but it has also brought about new risks and unfairness. To meet the demands of today's children, we need to take a comprehensive strategy that balances digital literacy with emotional intelligence, academic rigor with mental health, and fairness with opportunity. We can raise a generation that is strong, caring, and capable by understanding and responding to these complex realities.

**CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 1.3**

1. What is the negative impact of over screen time for children?
 - A. Improved critical thinking.
 - B. Reduced physical engagement and poor sleep.
 - C. Improved social relationship.
 - D. Improved educational achievement.

Answer: 1 - b

1.5 MULTIPLE CHILDHOODS**1.5.1 Childhood in Different Economic Contexts in India**

Time, space, social and geographical context, political and economic context and many other factors contribute to our conceptualisation of childhood and how children live and experience it (Kumar, 2025). India has a huge and diversified population, which presents unique challenges and opportunities for living and working in the country. Children's lives are very different depending on their family's income. These inequalities affect not only children's access to fundamental requirements like food, education, and healthcare, but also the bigger challenges they face to grow, be safe, and be involved. Some children have a privileged upbringing full of safety and opportunities, while others have to deal with deprivation, work, and being vulnerable from a young age. Viewing childhood in India through the lens of the economy offers valuable insights into the nation's development journey and highlights opportunities to create a more equitable and inclusive future for all children.

1.5.2 Childhood among the Higher Income Families

Children from well-off urban families in India often experience a globalised and enriching upbringing. They attend well-resourced schools, engage in diverse co-curricular activities such as music and sports, and develop digital skills from an early age. With access to quality healthcare, nutritious food, these children are encouraged to explore their interests and realise their full potential.

These children have all possible amenities such as separate room, study table, TV, computers, tablets and even mobile phones. They also get enough opportunities to play with toys they prefer. The parents also try to possess and save finances and property for their future. These families have domestic help for their children as both the parents are either working or engaged in some sort of business. The role of grandparents is to supervise if nanny is taking care of their children properly or not.

But even in this situation, new problems are coming up, such as too much academic pressure, not enough leisure time to play, and too much exposure to digital media. A NIMHANS study from 2019 found that anxiety and sadness had risen a lot among middle- and upper-class youngsters in cities. This is thought to be because of scholastic stress and social comparison that digital media encourages. So, even if children who are rich may not have to worry about survival, they are nevertheless at risk for psychological and developmental problems.

From the above discussion, it can be said that the childhood of higher income group is protected and under supervision. This is a stage of pampering and development under supervision of elders or caregiver. The childhood in higher income class is somewhat ideal form of childhood which is full of all possibilities, opportunities and support system.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 1.4

1. The childhood of higher income families in cities represents:
 - A. Limited access to education and healthcare
 - B. Independent living with minimal supervision
 - C. A structured, supervised routine with educational and recreational privileges



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D. Childhood focused entirely on traditional values with no use of technology.

Answer : 1 - c

1.5.3 Childhood in Middle Income Families

Being a child in India's middle-class families is a unique experience that combines traditional family values with hopes for modernisation and moving forward in the world. The experiences of children in these homes are affected by a combination of factors including access to school, exposure to technology, parental ambitions, and developing social standards. Even while they have more security and opportunities than children from low-income families, children in this class also deal with academic demands, social comparisons, and a shifting cultural landscape that makes their formative years unique. As resources are limited, the idea of sharing is learned by learners from very young age.

For most middle-income families in India, education is considered the primary vehicle for employment and social mobility. Children typically attend private or semi-private schools. Parents in this class place a high premium on academic achievement and are often involved in their child's educational journey through regular communication with teachers, assistance with homework, and the hiring of private tutors. This focus on academic success is driven by the desire to secure stable, respectable careers, often in engineering, medicine, or government service.

Middle-class families in India blend traditional values with modern aspirations, emphasising respect for elders, commitment to education, and appreciation of religious and cultural traditions that strengthen family bonds and moral grounding. Childhood experiences include festivals, family reunions, and religious traditions, all of which help kids feel like they belong and have an identity. At the same time, young children are seeing more of the world's culture through TV, smartphones, and the internet. This makes a world of local values and global goals.

Most children from middle-income families have access to digital devices like smartphones, tablets, or computers at home. People utilise these technologies for both fun and learning. A lot of children go to school online, use learning applications, or look for homework help on YouTube. But too much time in front of a screen is also a problem, with reports of less physical exercise and social engagement (Twenge & Campbell, 2018).

Most of the time, people only have free time on the weekends. This may involve trips to malls, movie theatres, or family members' homes. People are encouraged to have hobbies like music, dance, or athletics, but they are usually less important than their academic ambitions. People often only play in safe places like parks in gated communities or school playgrounds. This is because of safety concerns and the fact that there isn't enough room in cities.

Children from middle-income households have better material conditions than children from low-income families, yet they nonetheless have their own problems. The most important of these is the pressure to do well, which can cause emotional burnout. Social media makes things harder by showing children idealized lifestyles and making them feel bad about themselves by comparing themselves to others. However, with proper guidance, it can become a powerful tool for inspiration, self-expression, and learning, helping children build confidence and connect meaningfully with the world around them.

The middle-income children are generally better able to deal with new technologies and global prospects. They have access to education, health care, and social capital that can help them do well in a world that is becoming more competitive. These children can learn to be strong, flexible, and have a strong feeling of self-worth if they get the correct help.

So, being a child in India's middle class means having a mix of chances, goals, and limits. These children are stuck between what others used to demand of them and what they want to do now, and between rigid discipline and the need for freedom. They have access to good schools, stable families, and digital resources, but they also have to deal with mental stress and competition. Policymakers, teachers, and parents who want to raise not just high-achieving pupils, but also well-rounded people who need to understand the subtleties of their experiences.

1.5.4 CHILDHOOD IN LOWER INCOME FAMILIES

Children coming from lower income families typically have to deal with a lot of problems in their lives. Even while more people are enrolling in school, access to education is still not always available. Many government schools, especially in rural and tribal areas, have poor infrastructure, absence of teachers, and lack of learning resources (Annual Status of Education Report [ASER], 2022). This makes it hard to fill in learning gaps over time. The ASER study from 2022



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indicated that just 20% of third graders in government schools could read at a second-grade level. This number varied a lot depending on their family's income level.

A significant number of children from economically disadvantaged backgrounds continue to engage in labor, shouldering adult responsibilities at a young age. As a result, they are often vulnerable to exploitation and deprived of adequate opportunities for education, recreation, and holistic development. Childhood is often described as a time of innocence, learning, and growth. In India, children from diverse socio-economic backgrounds experience this phase in different ways. While many enjoy access to education, healthcare, and opportunities for development, others from low-income households face challenges that call for greater collective attention and action. Children from lower-income homes often grow up in overcrowded and unsafe living settings, such as slums or rural villages with minimal infrastructure. These families might not be able to get clean drinking water, toilets, power, or healthy food. The National Family Health Survey-5 (NFHS-5) says that more over 35% of children under five in India are stunted because they don't get enough food (Ministry of Health and Family Welfare [MoHFW], 2021). Malnourished children are more prone to suffer from illness, exhaustion, and cognitive deficits, which directly impact their ability to attend and perform in school.

Getting healthcare services is also very important. People don't always put preventive care, like vaccinations and health check-ups, at the top of their list because they don't have enough money or not aware about it. Because of this, children from families with low incomes are more likely to get sick, get infections, and have developmental problems that don't get treated (UNICEF, 2023).

Economic constraints often compel students to discontinue their education prematurely or balance schooling with work responsibilities. Child labour remains a persistent concern, particularly in informal sectors such as agriculture, domestic work, construction, and small-scale manufacturing. For many of these children, earning a livelihood takes precedence over education and recreation, limiting their access to a secure and nurturing childhood that supports holistic development. Children in low-income families face not just material deprivation but also emotional and psychological stress. The instability of daily life—due to hunger, illness, violence, or lack of parental attention—can lead to anxiety, low self-esteem, and behavioural problems. In families where parents work long

hours in low-paying jobs, children may be left unsupervised or cared for by older siblings. Girls, in particular, are burdened with domestic chores from an early age and are more likely to drop out of school to care for younger siblings or prepare for early marriage (Nambissan, 2010).

Social exclusion based on caste, religion, and gender often intersects with economic poverty to create additional barriers. Children from marginalized communities, such as Dalits or Adivasis, may face discrimination at school, in healthcare settings, or in their neighbourhoods. This exclusion limits their opportunities and reinforces cycles of poverty and inequality.

In summary, childhood among lower-income families in India is characterized by deprivation, resilience, and hope. These children encounter daily challenges that restrict their access to a healthy, secure, and fulfilling upbringing, yet they consistently display remarkable strength and adaptability in overcoming adversity. Addressing their needs calls for a comprehensive and integrated approach including enhanced public services, targeted policy interventions, active community participation, and inclusive development strategies. Such efforts are essential to ensure that every child, irrespective of economic background, enjoys equal rights, opportunities, and the foundation for a dignified future.

India requires a comprehensive and intersectional approach to address economic disparities affecting early childhood. Greater investment in public education and healthcare, particularly in underserved regions, is essential to ensure equitable access to basic services. Social protection programmes must be strengthened to more effectively support children from the most economically disadvantaged families. Additionally, increased focus on early childhood development is vital for fostering a healthier, more educated, and inclusive generation.

1.6 CHILDHOOD AND GENDER PERSPECTIVE

Usually, the dimension of gender regarding childhood is mostly discussed with regard to the difference between boys and girls. It is very rare when childhood is discussed with regard to being a boy or being a girl. Bartholomaeus and Senekevics (2015) looked at how gender affects family life for children from working-class origins. They used the idea of childhood as a gendered construction. Connell (2005) looked into how boys and girls interact with each other and how they do things every day. Anandalakshmy and Bajaj (1981) did an ethnographic study of the lives of children from a Momin Ansari community



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in Varanasi. This silk-weaving tribe in northern India kept its girls, some as young as four, from going anywhere but their own homes and the area around them. The work done by Ilaiah (1996) is also important to refer which explores the socialisation process of boys and girls in the Kuruma community, where boys are expected to learn sheep rearing activities (mostly outside work) and girls are expected to deal with husk, paddy, powder dry chillies etc (mostly household works). These studies show the difference in socialisation process of boys and girls. Even in educated urban cities such differences are visible in schools, family and community. However, families try to provide best possible opportunities to both boys and girls still their own socialisation hinder them in providing open and equal spaces to boys and girls.

There are many different ways that childhood is experienced in India, and these experiences are greatly affected by social, economic, cultural, and geographical influences. Gender is one of the most important things that affect childhood in India. Boys and girls are raised in various ways from birth, which often means that they have differing access to food, education, health care, and opportunity. There has been progress toward gender equality in the last few decades, but there are still many problems, especially for girls in lower-income families. The way boys and girls experience childhood affect not only their health right now, but also their future roles, responsibilities, and life paths.

In many parts of India, there is a significant preference for boys over girls, which starts even before birth. Sex-selective abortions still happen, even though they are against the law, which leads to an uneven sex ratio. The National Family Health Survey-5 (NFHS-5) says that in India, there were 929 females for every 1,000 boys at birth (MoHFW, 2021). This shows that gender-based discrimination is still happening before birth. Patriarchal traditions that link boys to financial security, inheritance rights, and religious duties are the reason for this preference for sons. In some contexts, girls are perceived as having lower economic value due to prevailing social customs such as dowry and traditional beliefs about their earning potential.

Gender equality in nutrition and healthcare is gradually gaining greater attention in India, reflecting a growing commitment to ensuring the well-being of every child. Although data such as NFHS-5 (MoHFW, 2021) indicate that 59.1% of adolescent girls (15–19 years) experience anaemia compared to 31.1% of boys, these insights have encouraged stronger policy focus and community awareness toward improving girls' health and nutrition. Increasingly, initiatives are being

implemented to promote equitable access to food and medical care within families, ensuring that both girls and boys receive the nourishment, healthcare, and support they need to grow and thrive.

Gender disparities in access to education continue to be an important area of focus. Over the past two decades, India has made remarkable progress in increasing girls' enrolment, reflecting growing awareness and policy commitment toward gender equality in education. However, challenges remain, particularly in rural and economically disadvantaged communities, where dropout rates among girls are still higher. According to the Unified District Information System for Education (UDISE) 2021–22 report, girls are more likely than boys to leave school at the secondary level, often due to economic pressures, family responsibilities, or early marriage. Ensuring access to safe school environments, adequate sanitation facilities, and supportive community systems can further empower adolescent girls to continue their education and realise their full potential.

Boys, on the other hand, are generally more likely to complete their schooling, though they too face gender-specific challenges. Many experience social pressure to conform to traditional masculine expectations, and in low-income households, some may leave school early to contribute financially to their families. While both genders encounter distinct barriers, girls often face deeper and more persistent structural disadvantages in terms of access to education and support.

Gender-based expectations influence not only access to education but also the overall course of childhood. Despite the legal age of marriage being 21, some girls in India continue to face the risk of early marriage. According to UNICEF (2022), India accounts for nearly one in four child marriages globally. Early marriage often interrupts girls' education and can expose them to health risks and social isolation. However, increasing awareness, stronger legal enforcement, and community initiatives are progressively contributing to a decline in child marriage, empowering more girls to continue their education and pursue their aspirations. Boys, on the other hand, are often socialised to become future breadwinners, which can lead to their early entry into the workforce.

From an early age, boys and girls are raised with distinct expectations. Girls are often encouraged to be gentle, disciplined, and family-oriented, while boys are granted greater freedom and guided to be assertive and ambitious.



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Family dynamics, educational practices, media representations, and religious teachings all contribute to reinforcing these societal norms. As a result, gender roles influence various aspects of children's lives, including playtime, clothing, responsibilities, and future aspirations. For instance, girls are more frequently assigned household chores, whereas boys often enjoy greater leisure time and freedom of movement (Nambissan, 2010).

These gendered expectations can limit the holistic development of children by restricting their ability to explore and express their identities freely. Girls may internalise feelings of inferiority, while boys might experience pressure to conform to rigid and sometimes harmful notions of masculinity.

Recognising these challenges, the Indian government and various non-governmental organizations have launched multiple initiatives to promote gender equality from early childhood. Programmes such as Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao aim to eliminate sex-selective practices and encourage girls' education, while schemes like Kasturba Gandhi Balika Vidyalaya provide residential schooling opportunities for girls from marginalised communities.

To ensure a truly equitable childhood, India must continue to address the root causes of gender imbalance. This includes challenging patriarchal norms, ensuring equitable access to quality education and healthcare, creating safe public spaces, and strengthening families through awareness and support programmes.

In conclusion, gender plays a pivotal role in shaping childhood experiences in India. While boys and girls share common aspects of growing up, deep-rooted gender biases continue to shape their opportunities, expectations, and life paths differently. Promoting gender equality from the earliest stages of life is not only vital for children's well-being but also essential for building a fair, inclusive, and equitable society. The nation's true advancement lies in ensuring that every child, regardless of gender, can grow up with dignity, equal opportunity, and the freedom to realise their full potential.

**CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 1.6**

1. Which one of the following is the most important concern of adolescent girls in India for low attendance in school?

- A. Inadequate sanitation facilities during menstruation
- B. Pressure to study in co-education
- C. Poor extracurricular activities
- D. Poor digital resources

Ans: A

1.7 CHILDHOOD AND DIGITAL WORLD

Rapid technological advancements have significantly contributed to the lives of growing children. One can observe digitalisation everywhere, say in school, at home, in society, in the market, and so on. Mobile phones and smart gadgets are part of children's lives. Mobile phones are part of everyone's life. This change reached its peak during Covid-19 and now has an obvious role to play in people's lives. The different digital social media platforms and apps are available to all children directly or indirectly, such as Facebook, Instagram, YouTube, WhatsApp, and many more. Along with these, online games are also part of growing up for children, which they can access on mobile phones, tablets, computers, etc. Needless to say, television is part of everybody's life these days, and children are not exceptional. This way, digitalisation has created a cosmic space for socialisation, and mostly in urban spaces, it sometimes has more influence on children than their parents, community, and school. It can also be said that digitalisation has also become a primary agent of socialization for children.

Digitalisation has both positive and negative impacts on childhood. As far as good impact is concerned, a lot of opportunities are being provided by digitalisation to the children to define their perspectives and understanding about self and others. Digitalisation has also supported a lot of learning processes in school and at home. The plethora of information available through digitalisation has helped learners immensely to develop a comprehensive perspective about the concept they are learning. Reports like *Children in a Digital World* (UNICEF, 2017) highlighted that technology has a significant role to play in children's lives, not only in developed countries but also in the poorest countries in the world. Digitalisation also supports children with disabilities significantly. Children with disabilities have been facilitated with various gadgets supported by technology, which has helped them in their better survival in the society. However, the impact of digitalisation on children's lives has not always been



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seen positively and has raised many questions on it. People do not agree on children's well-being through digitalization. Different kinds of threats during childhood, such as digital harassment, mental concerns, stereotypes, adultery, etc., have been submitted by psychologists and policymakers.

Digitalisation has made a big difference in schooling for children. Digital resources including e-books, instructional apps, and online learning platforms give children individualised, interactive, and fun ways to study (Livingstone & Blum-Ross, 2020). Digital learning became the main way to learn, especially during the COVID-19 pandemic. This showed that technology may help close educational gaps when traditional systems are broken (OECD, 2021). Also, technologies like augmented reality (AR) and artificial intelligence (AI) are making learning better by making hard-to-understand ideas easier for young people to understand.

Digitalisation makes children's informal learning better in addition to their formal schooling. Children can learn new things and explore their hobbies outside of school on sites like YouTube and other education platforms, and a variety of coding games. According to researches, children can utilize digital media to boost their creativity, problem-solving, and critical thinking skills if they are given the right guidance (Chaudron et al., 2018). Digital storytelling tools and game-based learning environments also promote learning by doing and working together.

But there are also big concerns that come with children using digital technology all the time. Too much time in front of a screen is one of the most talked-about problems. Studies demonstrate that children who spend a lot of time in front of computers may have trouble paying attention, sleeping well, and staying healthy (Twenge & Campbell, 2018). The American Academy of Paediatrics (2016) says that too much media use can lead to obesity, sleep problems, and behavioural issues, especially in young children. Also, digital games and social media may be very absorbing and even addictive, which might make people do things they don't want to do, like spend less time on physical activities and not talking to people in person.

Another important issue with the digitalisation during childhood is privacy and data protection. Many digital platforms take personal information from children and teens, often without clear ways for them to provide permission or for parents to keep an eye on them. This exposure can make children more

likely to be targeted by ads, watched, and even used for online exploitation (Livingstone, 2019).

The effect of digital information on children's emotional and social development is another complicated subject. Social media sites can be places for children to interact with others and express themselves, but they can also expose them to cyberbullying, unattainable beauty standards, and social comparison (Nesi et al., 2018). For younger children, being able to see unfiltered content can be bad for them, therefore it's important for parents to help them learn about media. It's important to teach children how to think critically about what they see online so they can use the internet safely.

Even with these problems, digitisation also helps with accessibility and inclusivity. Digital tools can be very helpful for children with impairments since they give them other ways to communicate and get involved (UNICEF, 2017). Speech-to-text apps and screen readers are examples of assistive technologies that can help people learn and get involved in ways that weren't possible before.

To sum up, digitisation is a big element of modern childhood that can't be avoided. It has big benefits for learning, creativity, and staying connected, but it also comes with health, privacy, and development dangers. To make sure that digitalisation has beneficial effects on children's lives, we need to take a balanced and informed approach that focuses on media literacy, parental participation, and ethical design. Policymakers, teachers, and families all need to work together to establish digital spaces that are safe, welcoming, and good for children's growth.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 1.7

1. As per the discussion in the chapter, which one of the following is the positive effect of technology (digitalisation) on children?
 - A. Challenge the need of formal education
 - B. Access to digital resources has made learning and creativity better.
 - C. Improved social activity and in-person interaction



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D. Decreased peer group interaction

2. What is a major concern associated with children's increased use of digital technology?

A. Better interaction with parents

B. Enhanced creative ability

C. Increased Social Interaction with community

D. Concern regarding cyberbullying and loss of privacy

Answer : 1 - b; 2 - d



1.8 LET US SUM UP

1. The idea of childhood is not set in stone or universal; instead, it is a social and historical idea that has changed over time.
2. In the past, people in Western societies didn't necessarily think of childhood as a separate stage of life.
3. In the 17th and 18th centuries, when Enlightenment ideas became popular, people began to consider childhood as a separate and significant time of life that needed special care, protection, and instruction.
4. Sociologists and anthropologists have criticised the prevailing developmental paradigm for ignoring the variety and independence of children's experiences.
5. There are many accounts in Indian mythology regarding the childhood of Krishna, Rama, and Durga, who are all kids.
6. Technology, family relationships, the economy, and how schools work have all transformed how children grow up, learn, and deal with the world.
7. Smartphones, tablets, and computers are becoming a big part of everyday life, even at school and at play. Because youngsters grow up with technology, people often term them "digital natives."
8. Children today are also shaped by how their families work. Divorce, single parenthood, and houses with two incomes have all become more common,

which has changed the way individuals used to care for others.

9. Children have greater pressure than ever to achieve well in school, and this pressure starts when they are very young. People could feel pressurised and apprehensive because of standardised testing and schools that are competitive.
10. Because of the significant variances in social and economic conditions across the country, childhood in India is highly diverse for everyone.
11. The childhood experiences of people with higher incomes is protected and watched over. This is a time for pampering and growth while being watched over by an adult or caretaker.
12. In India's middle class families, having a child means having a combination of possibilities, objectives, and constraints. These children are caught between what other people used to expect from them and what they want to do now. They are bound between strict rules and the urge for freedom.
13. Children from low-income households have a hard time, yet they are strong and hopeful. These children have to deal with problems every day that make it hard for them to have a happy, safe, and healthy childhood.
14. In India, gender is a very significant component of childhood. As boys and girls grow up, they may have certain things in common, but deep-seated gender biases make their chances, treatment, and expectations very different.
15. Digitisation is a key part of modern childhood that can't be ignored. It has a lot of good things, including helping you study, be creative, and remain in touch with people. But it also has health, privacy, and other risks.



1.9 END EXERCISES

1. Using suitable examples, discuss the idea that childhood is not a singular experience; instead, there are multiple childhoods in India.
2. Critically discuss the role of technology in today's world. How does technology shape the experiences during childhood in India?
3. With the help of a suitable example, discuss how gender is an important aspect that constitutes the course of development during childhood.



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4. How has the idea of childhood changed throughout the years?
5. How did thinkers like Locke and Rousseau help shape how we think about childhood today?
6. What are the contributing factors in shaping childhood in modern times?
7. Write some psychological concerns briefly that are faced by children of high-income families in cities.
8. What role gender plays during the childhood in India?

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